Some Facts

- Tsodilo is in Ngamiland, in the northwest of Botswana. Access is from a signposted road near the village of Nxamasere. This road is gravel and is suitable for 2x4 vehicles. However some of the sand roads around Tsodilo are only negotiable with 4x4 vehicles. There is also an airstrip and air charter services are available from Maun.

- Tsodilo is beautiful throughout the year. From April to September the heat and mosquitoes are not so apparent. There are seven hiking trails varying in length and difficulty to traverse. Community guides are available to assist tourists and tour operators.

- Tsodilo has a campsite, a museum complex with a staff office and ablution facilities for visitors. There is also a craft shop operated by the Tsodilo Community Trust.

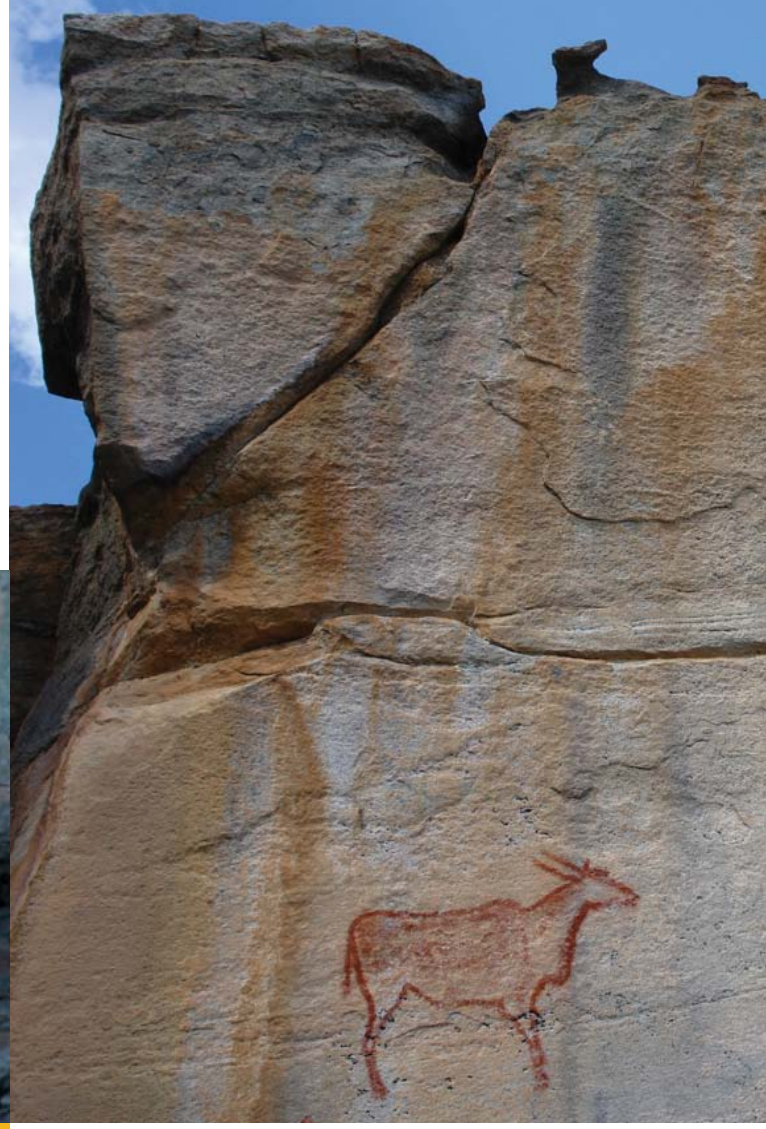
Some Rules

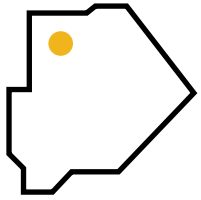
Tsodilo is a World Heritage Site and a National monument. It is administered by the Botswana National Museum and protected by the Monuments and Relics Act (2001). Adherence to some basic guidelines will make your visit all the more worthwhile and ensure the continued protection of a part of Botswana's unique heritage.

- Report to the main gate for assistance.
- Do not litter.
- PLEASE do not touch or interfere with the rock art or any feature.
- Do not remove any artifacts.
- Firearms and pets are not allowed.

PLEASE NOTE:
Researchers and commercial photographers, contact the Botswana National Museum for permission.







Designation:
Natural & Cultural
Area: approx. 3km²
Adoption priorities:
visitor interpretation centre, field assistants, signage, trails

For further information, contact:
The Archaeology Division, Botswana National Museum
Private Bag 00114 Gaborone, Botswana
Phone: +267 3974616 Fax: +267 3911186 / 3902797

TSODILO
hills
WORLD HERITAGE SITE

ADOPT A MONUMENT
GIVING LIFE TO BOTSWANA'S HERITAGE SITES

TS201511

Natural Heritage Site **Cultural Heritage Site**

TSODILO HILLS

Welcome to Tsodilo: Mountain of the Gods. Rising majestically from the surrounding Kalahari sand veld, Tsodilo hills are Botswana's highest peak at 1395 metres high and a sacred landmark. It is an area that has for thousands of years attracted people to live in, trade and visit. A local !kung legend, says that Tsodilo hills was once a family… father, mother and children, hence the names of the cliffs: Male, Female and Child. Tsodilo has many names: the local !Kung call it the copper bracelet; the Hambukushu refer to it as the precipitous rocks. Van der Post, in his book, Lost World of the Kalahari, described Tsodilo as the Slippery Hills. He also called it Mountain of the Gods… an appropriate name for one of Botswana's foremost natural wonders and timeless cultural sites.

Cultural Heritage

Tsodilo is one of Africa's premier rock art sites and Botswana's only World Heritage Site. Over 4 500 images have been painted at 400 sites. Most of these images date back to between 850AD and 1100AD.

Consisting of red and white images, as well as rock paintings, they portray wild and domestic animals, geometric patterns, human and even what appears to be a whale! These images were finger-painted using pigments ground from haematite (red), charcoal and calcrete (white) and possibly mixed with animal fat, blood, egg white, honey, sap or urine.

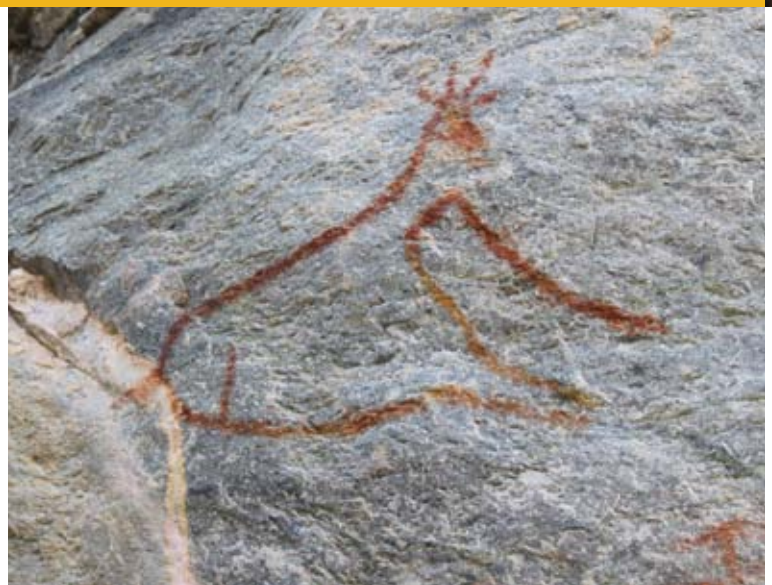




The Rock Paintings

Tsodilo is also rich in archaeological finds. Three rock shelters, White Painting Shelter, Depression Rock Shelter and Rhino Cave have been excavated. Over twenty specularite mines and the remains of two villages Divuyu and N!oma dating back to 800 AD have been uncovered. Pots, metal spearheads, stone tools, glass beads and even fish bones derived from lake Tsodilo which existed 10 000 years ago, have been found and help form a picture of ancient life here. From these artifacts we know of local communities and immigrants from the Zambezi and Congo rivers who were involved in trade, body decoration, the production of stone tools, pottery and jewellery, as well as the keeping of cattle and small livestock.

Research suggests that our distant relatives have been at Tsodilo for perhaps 100 000 years and local communities there have had rich cultures for over 1,000 years-still apparent in the !Kung and Hambukushu communities that live around Tsodilo today.



Natural Heritage

Tsodilo's timeless cultural heritage is matched by its natural beauty. It is visited by the leopard, vervet monkey, antbear, warthog, brown hyaena, kudu, wilddog, elephant and the Tsodilo Rock Gecko. That is found nowhere else. Tsodilo is also a great source of honey. There are many species of birds and insects. There is also a diversity of plants including baobabs, acacias, the morula, mophane and plants such as sengaparile, a tuber marketed as the Kalahari Devil's Claw. The Kalahari Devil's Claw is used as a cure for high blood pressure. There is also the mongongo tree that produces a nut high in protein which has been a local source of food for at least 9 000 years!